PORTLAND PUBLIC SCHOOLS

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STAFF REPORT

Date: **May 12, 2026**

To: Board of Education

CC: Dr. Kimberlee Armstrong, Superintendent

From: Isaac Cardona, Chief of Schools

Subject: Jason Lee Elementary School Name Change

BACKGROUND

Jason Lee Elementary is a vibrant Title I school in Northeast Portland that serves a diverse and dynamic student community. The school is deeply committed to creating an inclusive and welcoming environment where all students feel a strong sense of belonging and are supported to succeed. Jason Lee serves a student population that is predominantly students of color, with a rich mix of cultural and linguistic backgrounds, and provides a wide range of support, including special education services and access to community-based resources through their SUN school program. The school is known for its strong community engagement, including events that celebrate and honor the identities of its students and families, such as Black Brilliance, Lunar New Year, and Festival de la Familia. Staff and community members work collaboratively to ensure that students are supported academically, socially, and emotionally, with a shared commitment to equity, inclusion, and high expectations for all students.

In May 2023, a group of parents initiated a request to change the name of Jason Lee Elementary, gathering over 70 signatures from students, staff, and community members in support of renaming the school. The request was grounded in concerns that the current namesake, Jason Lee, a 19th-century missionary associated with the displacement and forced reeducation of Indigenous communities, does not reflect the values of the current school community or the district's commitment to racial equity and social justice.

The Board approved moving forward with the renaming process in March 2024, initiating a multi-year effort grounded in community engagement, student voice, and alignment to Board policy.

A Renaming Committee was formed, composed of students, staff, parents, and community members. The committee met regularly over the course of two years to design and implement a process that centered on inclusivity, transparency, and meaningful engagement across the school community.

RELATED POLICIES/BEST PRACTICE

A. 2.20.010-P Naming School District Property

B. 2.20.011-AD Procedures for Naming School District Property

The renaming process followed Board policy, including the development of a written rationale, establishment of a representative committee, and implementation of a community engagement and voting process aligned to district expectations.

FISCAL IMPACT

There will be costs associated with renaming the school, including updates to signage, materials, and communication systems. Initial estimates for the renaming process were just under $30,000. The school community has expressed a strong willingness to partner in offsetting these costs through fundraising and is actively exploring strategic approaches to reduce overall expenses. Final costs will depend on the scope of implementation and the timeline for completing necessary updates.

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

The renaming process was intentionally designed to center student voice and broad community participation.

Key components of the engagement process included:

- Formation of a Renaming Committee composed of students, staff, parents, and community members
- Development of committee norms focused on collaboration, inclusivity, and shared decision-making
- Implementation of classroom lessons to support student understanding of community values and “change-makers,” aligned to district equity commitments
- Collection of name proposals through staff, students, and community submissions
- Review and narrowing of potential names based on alignment to district values and historical accuracy

The final ballot included both symbolic names and names of regional change-makers. Voting was conducted over a one-month period in February–March 2026 and was available in multiple languages, including English, Spanish, and Vietnamese.

A total of 446 participants cast 483 votes (some selected multiple names), representing students, families, staff, alumni, and community members.

Based on the results of the voting process, the name **“Sunrise Elementary School”** received the highest level of support from the community, significantly exceeding all other options.

The name “Sunrise” reflects themes of renewal, hope, and new beginnings, and was identified by the community as a symbol that represents both the current identity of the school and its aspirations for the future.

In addition to selecting a new name, the school community has expressed a commitment to honoring and acknowledging the Indigenous history of the region and is working with district partners and local tribes to ensure that this work continues beyond the renaming process.

STAFF RECOMMENDATION

After reviewing the comprehensive community engagement process, alignment with Board policy, and the results of the community vote, the Office of the Superintendent recommends that the School Board approve the renaming of Jason Lee Elementary School to:

Sunrise Elementary School

This decision reflects a thorough and inclusive process that centered student voice, community input, and alignment with district values. Approval of this name will support a stronger sense of belonging and identity for the Jason Lee Elementary community moving forward.

As a PPS Executive Leadership Team member, I have reviewed this staff report.

_____ *(Initials)*

ATTACHMENTS

A. Resolution